

Naphthalene can be refined to high levels of purity. Coal tar pitch can serve as a key raw material for lithium-ion battery anodes.

Developing such capabilities has taken years of process refinement and experimentation.

To Choudhary, the ability to control both process and product development internally remains one of the organisation's strongest advantages.

It also helps shield the business from supply chain volatility. Himadri's primary raw material is coal tar, a by-product of steel manufacturing that is largely sourced domestically from Indian steel plants, giving it a degree of insulation from the import dependence and global trade disruptions.

The past few years have been marked by supply disruptions, energy price fluctuations and uneven industrial demand. Such periods, Choudhary says, reinforce the importance of patience and long-term thinking. He chose to maintain the company's focus on specialty products while continuing to invest in research and capacity expansion.

One example is the addition of a new specialty carbon black line at the facility in Singur, West Bengal. The 70,000 MTPA line increased total specialty carbon black capacity to 130,000 MTPA.

Another step was the acquisition of Birla Tyres, building on the company's long association with the tyre industry through its carbon black business and offers an opportunity to understand end-use applications more closely. The decision reflects an effort to deepen the firm's understanding of how its materials perform across industries.

Analysts appear to have bought into this approach. "Himadri is entering a new investment phase with capacity expansion across coal tar distillates, specialty carbon black and battery chemicals. These additions should support volume growth over the next few years and deepen the company's

specialty portfolio, though margins will depend on spreads and the pace of ramp-up of new capacities," says Sanjesh Jain and Mohit Mishra, analysts at ICICI Securities.

The company has also expanded its international presence, and exports to 56 countries now. It has invested in logistics infrastructure, including terminals at Haldia and New Mangalore Port. These facilities strengthen the company's ability to serve Southeast Asia, Australia and West Asia.

Financial discipline has also been central to Choudhary's approach. Himadri became debt-free by the end of FY24 and maintains a strong net cash position. Much of the company's expansion has been funded through internal accruals. Return on capital employed remains above 30%. Maintaining a strong balance sheet, Choudhary says, provides the freedom to invest in technology and research without being constrained by debt.

That also allows the firm to pursue opportunities patiently rather than reacting to short-term market cycles.

Choudhary is increasingly focused on technologies linked to energy storage and electric mobility. Lithium-ion battery materials represent one of the most important areas of focus.

As electric vehicles and energy storage systems gain traction worldwide, demand for advanced battery components is rising. Himadri is building capabilities across both anode and cathode chemistries to participate in this ecosystem.

The company is developing a lithium iron phosphate cathode active material facility with a planned capacity of 200,000 metric tonnes in phases.

At the same time, research teams are advancing work on next-generation anode technologies including natural, synthetic, hybrid and silicon-carbon materials. To strengthen its work in this area, Himadri has entered partnerships with Sicona Battery Technologies in Australia and International Battery

01 **Choudhary places in-house research at the centre of Himadri's strategy and product development**

02 **The company has moved beyond coal tar pitch into specialty carbon black, refined naphthalene and battery materials**

03 **Himadri converts coal tar and related feedstocks into multiple specialised chemical products**

04 **The company turned debt-free in FY24 while maintaining strong return on capital employed**

05 **It is building capabilities for electric mobility**

